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**ATTEMPTS TO REVIVE
THE COPTIC LANGUAGE IN EGYPT,
AND RELEVANT PROBLEMS**

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ATTEMPTS TO REVIVE THE COPTIC LANGUAGE
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In many Countries , the Coptic Language may have its importance from a theological , historical or archaeological point of view, but to Copts , it has the further value of being an identity

After the Arab Conquest of Egypt, the invaders succeeded in imposing their Arabic Language on the Egyptian tongue , but the Coptic Church had the honour of keeping the national language of Egypt in its books , prayers & rites.

The motive here was not religious , since one can pray in any language. It was a national motive , in order to save Egypt's Language and identity. We hope that someday all Egypt - not only the Copts & the foreign scholars - will take care of the Coptic Language. This can only occur if all the Egyptians - not only the Copts - might realize the fact that they are Egyptians , not Arabs.

It is not easy that a people changes its language , but if ruled for a lot of centuries by foreigners who speak only their language , one has to learn it , in order to deal with them , especially if they are cruel & violent.(1)

Also speaking Arabic became a must for anybody who would like to keep his job , according to the instructions of the Arab ruler.(2)

Later an Arab Fatimid Ruler called Al-Hakim prohibited speaking Coptic. He was a mad man & it was impossible to keep alive if you disobey him.(3)

The Coptic Language disappeared as a living language. The Copts kept it in dictionaries called " Al Sullam " & in grammar books called " Al Mokaddimah " , written in the period from the eleventh to the fourteenth century , anno domini.(4)

In the nineteenth & twentieth centuries , the Copts partially got rid of the yoke of discrimination & persecution. New books appeared in Egypt in order to teach the Copts their Language.

Also a lot of books appeared abroad , written by great foreign scholars of Coptology & Egyptology , which helped in reviving the Coptic Language in Egypt.

In Egypt , Ikladios Labib , in Cairo , compiled a Coptic - Arabic Dictionary & wrote a lot of grammar & teaching books. His family spoke Coptic.

Mr. Pissenty in Alexandria taught Coptic to his brothers & sisters , & brought up his nephews & nieces speaking Coptic as their mother tongue. Also Mr. Meawwad Abdel Nour speaks Coptic with his wife & students in Alexandria.

Dr. Imil Maher Ishaq in Cairo speaks Coptic with the students of his department in the Institute of Coptic Language. Also there is a group of graduates of the Institute of Coptic Studies, & students of the Institutes of Coptic Studies & Coptic Language whom I (Dr. Kamal Farid Ishaq) taught Coptic & we do speak Coptic in our monthly meeting.

The difficulties which face the attempts to revive the Coptic Language in Egypt include :

1. Difficulties in the vocabulary :

How to compensate for the lost words & how to suggest new words needed in modern life.

2. Difficulties in syntax & morphology :

Some expressions are not easy to express in Coptic. There is no perfect participle in Coptic. Adjectives are few , & a lot of verbs have no qualitative form. Some Greek loan words are too long to be accepted by the modern Copt who wishes to speak Coptic.

It is impossible for Coptic to be a living language if we confine ourselves to what we received in texts. We have to derive new words & expressions , on a scientific basis.

3. The lack of modern Coptic literature , the lack of teachers of the Coptic Language especially efficient teachers. Also the lack of suitable students of the Coptic Language. The majority of young people prefer to learn a living language , to help them in earning living.

4. Difficulties in Phonetics :

Some Copts began to pronounce the Coptic according to what Dr.Imil Maher Ishaq suggested. The majority refuse this , & stick to the current ecclesiastic pronunciation. This schism causes the disappointment of a lot of scholars , it is difficult for each group to understand the other pronunciation.

5. Social & Political Difficulties :

These difficulties arise from the name of the Coptic Language i.e.from the word " Coptic ".

The majority of the population of Egypt who are not christian misunderstand the word " Coptic ". They combine this word with the Christian Religion. They are not aware that

the word " Coptic " means " Egyptian " & that the Coptic Language is a heritage of all Egypt.

The Egyptian government does not encourage the suggestion of having a department of Coptology in any Egyptian University. Nobody is aware that it is a national duty to take care of the Coptic Language.

I have been trying to find solutions to the above-mentioned difficulties :

For example , in order to compensate for the defects in the vocabulary in the Bohairic Dialect - which is the Dialect used nowadays by the copts - I had to :

1. Borrow loan words from other languages.
e.g. **ᲥᲙᲁᲓ** or **ᲥᲙᲓᲛ** for "tea", from modern greek (5),
ᲠᲁᲗᲓᲟ for " radio " , from English & French.
2. Borrow words from other Coptic Dialects , & modify them - if needed - to Bohairic morphology.
e.g. I borrowed from the Sahidic Dialect the verb **ⲭⲱⲗⲱ** which means " to make merry " or similar meanings such as " to be merry " (6) & I changed it to the Bohairic form **ᲪⲱᲗᲉᲘ**. I used it in the meaning " to celebrate ".
N.B. : The word **ᲪⲱᲗᲉᲘ** has been also found in the Bohairic Dialect but only as a noun.
3. Derive new words from the Bohairic Dialect itself.
e.g. From **ᲙⲱᲧᲛ** " to choose " I derived **ᲙⲱᲧᲛⲓⲛᲉᲛᲧ** " to prefer ",literally " to choose by the heart " . , in addition to **ᲙⲱᲧᲛⲓⲛ** = , e.g. **ᲥᲙⲱᲧᲛⲓⲛ᲏Დ** "I prefer "(literally:" I choose for myself ")
From **ᲙᲱᲓ** " to know ",I derived **ᲙᲱᲓⲛᲉᲛᲧ** "to feel " ,Literally " to know by the heart ".
From **ᲓᲱᲓ**"to wash",I derived **ᲠᲙᲙᲱᲓ** "washing-machine"
cf. **ᲠᲙᲙᲱᲓ** " a man or woman who washes ".
N.B.:I derived the Syllable **ᲠᲙᲙ** on analogy of the syllable **ᲠᲙᲙ** to express a neuter present participle.
From **ᲓᲱᲧ** "father" ,I derived * **ᲓᲱᲧᲱ** "grandfather " ,and from **ᲙᲁᲧ**"mother",I derived * **ᲙᲁᲧᲱ** "grandmother" by adding **Ჱ** " great " to **ᲓᲱᲧ** or **ᲙᲁᲧ** (7).
4. I chose some Coptic words to express relevant meanings
e.g. the word **ᲧᲁᲧᲉᲟ** which is found only as a noun or as a verb in the qualitative form (8). I used it also as an infinitive absolute form meaning " to impede or restrain ".
No doubt it was used thus by our ancestors , it is not logic to deny this only because we could not find it in an old text.
5. To form a Coptic word acting as a perfect or past participle ,I suggested putting a prefix before the verb,such as:

ⲱⲁⲡ-(9) participium conjunctivum from **ⲱⲱⲡ** "to receive".

ⲉⲁⲓ-(10) participium conjunctivum from **ⲉⲓ** "to take".

Ⲣⲁ-(11) a prefix most probably derived from **Ⲣⲁ** "to do", sometime used to indicate place (giving a local sense), and here I mean to indicate the thing or person on which the effect of the verb was done.

Example : (using the verb **ⲕⲱⲱ** "to break" of which no Bohairic qualitative form reached us.) In order to get a word meaning "broken" I can use one of the above-mentioned prefixes or I can derive a qualitative form, in addition to the usual expression : **ⲡⲉⲧⲟⲧ ⲕⲁⲱⲥ** & **ⲡⲉⲧⲁⲧ ⲕⲁⲱⲥ** & **ⲱⲟⲧ ⲕⲁⲱⲥ** (12), which can be used but do not mean the word "broken" precisely.

So we have :

* **ⲱⲁⲡⲕⲱⲱ**, * **ⲉⲁⲓⲕⲱⲱ**, * **Ⲣⲁⲕⲱⲱ**, * **ⲕⲏⲱ** (+), & * **ⲕⲱⲱ** (+)

* **ⲱⲁⲡⲕⲱⲱ** & * **ⲉⲁⲓⲕⲱⲱ** mean literally :
"receiver of breaking"

* **Ⲣⲁⲕⲱⲱ** means the thing to which or in which breaking was done.

* **ⲕⲏⲱ** +(13) is a qualitative form derived on analogy of **ⲃⲏⲁ**

* **ⲕⲱⲱ** is a qualitative form derived on analogy of the Sahidic qualitative form **ⲕⲟⲱⲉ**, but **ⲕⲏⲱ** is preferred because its construction is similar to the other Coptic qualitative forms of this type of verb which has an absolute form composed of 2 consonants & an omega between them.

N.B. : Sometimes the infinitive was used as a participle e.g.

ⲟⲩⲱⲓⲥⲓ ⲡⲉ, **ⲟⲩⲉⲁⲱⲓⲟ ⲁⲛ ⲡⲉ** "born, not created" (14) and

ⲡⲓⲱⲱⲡ ⲙⲁ ⲉⲁⲧ "(the thing) bought by money" (15).

But this way to get past participles cannot be generalized, because what is meant by this way of expression can be confused with other meanings of same word, because the infinitive is also used as a noun, e.g. from **ⲉⲁⲧ** "to speak" we get **ⲡⲓⲉⲁⲧ** "the word", so we cannot use the same word " **ⲡⲓⲉⲁⲧ** " to mean "the spoken", for fear of confusion, so the above-mentioned way of expression can be used only in selected cases to express the past participle.

6. I restricted the use of some words to one meaning only among their several meanings.

e.g. the word **ⲟⲩⲱⲛⲉ ⲉⲃⲟⲗ** has three meanings :
"to appear", "to confess" & "to thank"

I restricted using the first part which is **ⲟⲩⲱⲛⲉ** to the meaning "to appear".

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- (5) J.T. Pring , The Oxford dictionary of Modern Greek 1990, Clarendon press , Oxford.
- (6) W.E. Crum , A Coptic Dictionary , 1979 , Oxford Clarendon Press ,p. 768 b.
- (7) Crum , p. 253 a.
- (8) Crum , p. 439 b.
- (9) Crum , p. 575 a.
- (10) Crum , p. 747 b.
& Mallon p. 137 § 276.
- (11) Crum , p. 287 a:
cf. **ⲡⲁⲧⲱⲙⲓ** : " joint " (a joined place) , and
ⲡⲁⲱⲁⲧ : " loss, deficit (a lost money) "
- (12) (a) **ⲉⲧⲟⲩⲕⲁⲱϥ** cf. Mallon p. 137 § 273.
(b) **ⲱⲟⲩ ⲕⲁⲱϥ** cf Crum p. 600 b. cf **ⲱⲟⲩⲉⲣ
ⲉⲡⲓⲑⲧⲓⲛ** " **ἐπιθυσήτος** " & Crum 603 b. cf
ⲱⲟⲩⲱⲟⲩⲱⲓ " sacrifice , offering " (thing
offered) "
- (13) Crum p. 130 b & Mallon p90 § 207.
- (14) The apostles' Creed , Kitab Alkhulagy al Mukaddas (Euchologion) , Cairo , all prints.
- (15) Mallon , p. 161 (Gen 17 , 12).

